Like the bishop of Brixen, other churchmen were initially sceptical of Kramer's wild ideas, and there was some resistance to the book among church experts.[74] But *The Hammer of the Witches* became one of the biggest bestsellers of early modern Europe. It catered to people's deepest fears, as well as to their lurid interest in hearing about orgies, cannibalism, child murders and satanic conspiracies. The book had gone through eight editions by 1500, another five by 1520, and sixteen more by 1670, with many vernacular translations.[75] It became the definitive work on witchcraft and witch-hunting and inspired a host of imitations and elaborations. As Kramer's fame grew, his work was embraced by the church experts. Kramer was appointed papal representative and made inquisitor of Bohemia and Moravia in 1500. Even today his ideas continue to shape the world, and many current theories about a global satanic conspiracy – like QAnon – draw upon and perpetuate his fantasies.

While it would be an exaggeration to argue that the invention of print *caused* the European witch-hunt craze, the printing press played a pivotal role in the rapid dissemination of the belief in a global satanic conspiracy. As Kramer's ideas gained popularity, printing presses produced not only many additional copies of *The Hammer of the Witches* and copycat books but also a torrent of cheap one-page pamphlets whose sensational texts were often accompanied by illustrations depicting people attacked by demons or witches burned at the stake.[76] These publications also gave fantastic statistics about the size of the witches' conspiracy. For example, the Burgundian judge and witch-hunter Henri Boguet (1550–1619) speculated that there were 300,000 witches in France alone and 1.8 million in all of Europe.[77] Such claims fuelled mass hysteria, which in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries led to the torture and execution of between 40,000 and 50,000 innocent people who were accused of witchcraft.[78] The victims included individuals from all walks of life and ages, including children as young as five.[79]

People began denouncing one another for witchcraft on the flimsiest evidence, often to avenge personal slights or to gain economic and political advantage. Once an official investigation began, the accused were often doomed. The inquisitorial methods recommended by *The Hammer of the Witches* were truly diabolical. If the accused confessed to being a witch, they were executed and their property divided between the accuser, the